

PETERSHELLEYEDITED

Travel Radio Australia. We're here at the World Travel Market in London and I've run into Peter Shelley from the Australian Tourism Export Council. Peter, welcome to the program.

Yeah, great to be here. Now, Peter, tell us a bit about the ATEC and what you guys do. You help a bunch of companies here to get their message out to the Europeans and all over the world.

Yeah, that's right. We're a large national association from Australia, Tourism Export Council, and what we do is we try and help our members become better at trying to export their business and their product and their experiences to everybody internationally. So that's really important for us.

We do quite a few things. We talk to the government a lot about, say, things like visas, you know. Anybody got into trouble with visas, we talk to the government about trying to remove those challenges.

We help people understand the different markets. You know, in Australia, there's a lot of different people come from different countries to be in Australia. So we're trying to help our members understand what different nationalities, type of experiences that they would like to experience.

And we're also very big on standards to make sure everybody's really professional and all that sort of thing. So we do a bunch of things, but it's great being here at WTM. This is a huge show.

I think about 3,500 different tourism experiences from all across the world. It's just stunning to look out at all the different booths that are here. And from an Australian point of view, we're here with a small gathering of some really high-quality tourism providers, and we're here to punch above our weight and make sure that Australia and New Zealand are on the world stage.

It's a fantastic stand you have here, and I just spoke to Hazza, and he's a fantastic guy from his company. He does tours all around, and it's a fantastic experience for these small companies. And you help them.

A lot of them can't afford their own big stand here, but they can jump onto you and just become part of the program. It's a really good way for a group like Hazza, who's got a wonderful eco-tourism product in South Australia, very high, highly rated, but yeah, couldn't afford to get here on his own. And the same for the 40 others that are here on our booth today.

But collectively, we can subsidize and help out each other and really sort of put a footprint on the world stage with all of those different operators. And of course, in Australia, we've got so many different operators from so many different states. This is only a small part of our membership, but we're using this as a bit of an experiment to see what the update's like.

I'm speaking with Peter Shelley from the Australian Tourism Export Council, and Peter, the experience here in 2025 for this show has been fantastic for the people who've attended, right?

Yeah, it really has. It's been, it's blown their socks off, to be honest, to see so many really interested buyers, what we call them, wholesalers out of the European market, very interested to come to Australia. It's very exciting.

The Tourism Export Council of Australia is, how did it get started? How did it get going? Yeah, that's a really good question. We've just gone over 50 years. It's been around quite a while and it started as called the Inbound Tour Operators Association of Australia.

And it started back when international travel started to Australia and there was a lot of people wanting to come to Australia. We had people who were facilitating tours. We had a hell of a lot of people interested in providing experiences like hotels and cruise operators, but there was no organisation to bring that all together.

And so the industry got together and created this. And off the back of that, it really was the foundation of Inbound Tourism to Australia. And it's grown and grown and grown over those many years to be a really important export industry for our country.

And Australia is the number one on the bucket list for so many people in America, Europe, and especially the Europeans and the younger people say that the backpacker market is absolutely huge, isn't it, in Australia? We get excited about the backpacker market for a couple of reasons. Look, it's a wonderful group of people. We just love young people travelling to this country.

The backpacker market is really important for us. They travel into the regions, which is really important. They stay a long time.

They spend a lot of money. They also provide a great labour source for the industry as well. So there's so many dimensions to our working holidaymaker market, which is also known as the backpacker market.

And at the moment, we've got record numbers in this country, which is just tremendous. So after COVID, the number of young people that want to come and travel and stay in Australia has been really, really exciting. Now, the rules on that, is it under 25 or under 35? I'm not clear, but you can stay up to a year and work, right? That's right.

Yeah, so it's really interesting. So it works both ways. So it's under 35 and you can come and stay for a year.

If you do a little bit of work in the regions, because we need people to go into the regions to pick some grapes or fruit or, you know, whether it's difficult to get seasonal labour. And if you do 88 days, you can get the chance to stay another year. And if you do it again in the second year, you can get a chance to stay a third year.

So we love these guys. They're just tremendous. And the thing I really adore about them is they

become ambassadors for the country.

You know, they really become part of the routine. They will bring their family back when they get married. They'll often bring their relatives back.

So they come back two, three, four, five times as basically ambassadors to the country. And I was speaking to a guy, he's a chef in France and he's 30 years old. And he said, would I get a job? I said, Oh, absolutely.

He's like a specialist pastry chef. I said, they are crying out for people in hospitality in Australia. So if you are, we think you're coming down.

It's a good thing. Yeah, that's so true. That's so true.

Like it's not, it's skilled and unskilled that we're really looking for. And we're a big industry or a big and sprawling industry. We've got opportunities all over the country where there's jobs available.

And it's so right. Those skilled areas in hospitality, cheffing in particular, very, very popular and very much in need. So yeah, look, I'd just encourage anybody just thinking about a long-term holiday and is looking for an adventure of a lifetime.

Come on down to Australia. Now, Peter Shelley, Australian Tourism Export Council. How can people find out more about you guys online? Oh, look out.

Well, we're a trade organisation, but we're always happy to, for consumers to have a look at our website. We're atech.net.au and it's a trade website. So it's not really like trying to sell Australia.

But if you wanted to look at somewhere that's selling Australia, I'd encourage you to go to the Australian tourism website and you'll see lots of product available, lots of opportunity to come and stay here and have a great holiday. Thank you so much, Peter. It's a wonderful thing you're doing for Australian businesses here in London and congratulations on all the work you're carrying out.

Yeah, thanks very much. Been a real privilege to have a chat. Cheers.